

White-tailed deer

Odocoileus virginianus

Although widespread and found in large numbers, the white-tailed deer often stays out of sight. For most of the year, the deer live alone, occupying small home ranges of about a square mile. They set up home in swamps, woodlands, and scrubland—wherever there are plenty of shrubs to conceal them. They move slowly, constantly on the lookout for predators such as mountain lions. If danger appears, the deer whistle with alarm and bound away, waving their white tails to startle attackers.

The deer's territory provides all the food they need for the year, even in the northern fringe of their range where winters are long and severe. The deer do not leave when winter comes, but follow well-trodden paths through the snow looking for any greenery they can access. In winter, their coat is gray, but it thins in summer and turns red.

Spotted disguise

The females are ready to breed in fall, and males deploy their antlers to battle it out for the rights to each mate. Fawns are born in spring and lie hidden under shrubs while the mother is away feeding. They begin to follow their mothers in a month and are weaned when three months old. Their spotty coat, which helps them hide when young, is lost in the first winter.

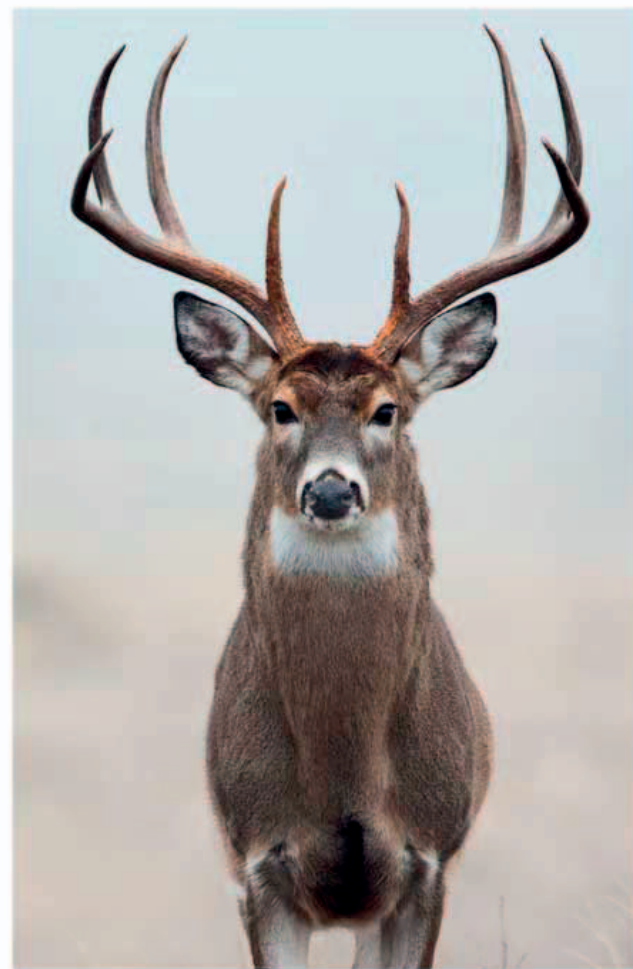
- ↔ 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m)
- ⚖ 115–310 lb (52–140 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Buds, leaves, twigs, cacti
- 🏠 



S. Canada
to N. South
America

▷ MATURE BUCK

Only male white-tailed deer have antlers, growing a fresh set each year. A new point, or tine, is added with each growth.



American pika

Ochotona princeps

The American pika looks like a cross between a guinea pig—with short legs and a large head—and a rabbit, with round ears and a whiskered face. Its long tail is hidden in fur. Lively in daylight, the animal bounds across scree slopes, pausing to make birdlike “cheeps” that warn of

the presence of predators, such as coyotes, weasels, and stoats, or far-carrying “mews” to assert its territory. This consists of a foraging area and a den in a burrow or rock crevice. Pikas live next to a member of the opposite sex, giving a male–female patchwork of territories.

In summer, the pika gathers flowering stems, such as fireweed, and long grasses. These are stored in a pile near its burrow and left to dry. As winter approaches, the pika drags its hay pile deep into a rock cavity, keeping its food store safe from the snow. Pikas select plants that will decompose the most slowly to ensure their food store will last them through the winter. This animal is adapted to high, cold places, but climate change has squeezed it into an ever-shrinking range.

▷ MAKING HAY

Pikas forage for grasses and herbs, eating some each day and caching the rest in their winter hay store.



short, thick fur
protects from
the cold

- ↔ 6–9 in (15–23 cm)
- ⚖ 4–6 oz (113–170 g)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌿 Grasses, herbs
- 🏠 



SW.
Canada,
W. US

Pikas use their **cheek glands** to **scent-mark** their territory